belt of the wearer, allowing greater freedom of movement. This ‘absurd style’ according to Badauni, did not find favour for very long but the jama itself slowly infiltrated the courts, the towns, and the villages in the furthest reaches of the empire. Over the jama the courtiers wore the choga, a loose wool or silk overcoat. Akbar was especially fond of shawls from Kashmir and had begun the fashion of wearing them thrown over the shoulder, loose or folded. They were made from shahtoos, the soft wool from the underbellies of mountain goats collected from bunches of thorns the animals had run over. To further make these clothes familiar and acceptable to all his subjects, Akbar developed new Hindavi terms for these items of clothing, and introduced the word sarbgati (covering the whole body) for jama, sis-shobah for cap, parmnaram, for shawl, and, for the burqa, the decidedly whimsically named chitra-gupita. Rajput courtiers in an earlier time used to wear only crisp white dhotis, elaborately pleated; their torsos bare, with a cloth sometimes thrown around the shoulders. Under the influence of the Mughal court, Rajput clothes became more elaborate and included a long coat, in the style of the Mughal jama, with a lining in the winter. The clerics meanwhile wore traditional long costumes and members of the Sufi order wore distinguishing ochre yellow and cinnamon robes. The courtiers all wore the small, compact, ‘atpati’ turbans, preferred by Akbar, decorated with ornaments, with clerics and scholars favouring voluminous, large headdresses. Courtly etiquette dictated that courtiers emulate the Padshah so styles would quickly adapt themselves to Akbar’s tastes, all the noblemen wearing the styles and jewels preferred by the Padshah.

On this auspicious occasion Akbar may have worn in his turban a special ruby presented to him by Hamida Banu on the birth of Salim, and which he took to wearing as a sarpech (turban ornament). For all the distracting ceremonial around the beginning of schooling, the education of the royal princes, as indeed of all the mirzas and the children of the noblemen, was an extremely vital element of courtly culture. ‘In society,’ warned the eighteenth-century Mirza Namah to a nobleman, ‘he should try to guard against the shame of committing any mistake in conversation, for such incorrectness in speech is considered a great fault in a Mirza.’ A faultless knowledge of the great texts of the time, in Persian and Arabic, and even Hindustani, was considered de rigueur to be able to carry out scintillating and erudite conversations, introducing apt quotes from the texts at relevant moments. The young mirzas began by memorizing some verses